Tandem: next-quarter plan

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Summary

Fix sync, ship SSO for Brightwell, and improve teammate invites and mobile onboarding. This uses 30 of 36 engineer-weeks and keeps 6 in reserve, since estimates are ±25%. Calendar sync, the AI assistant, Gantt and dark mode wait: none has evidence as strong as the sync churn data or Brightwell's written $180k commitment.

What the data says

- **Sync is the main problem.** Tickets went from 140 to 520 a month after the July offline-mode launch. Sync is the top reason for cancelling (31%).
- **Churn is rising.** Monthly paid churn went from 3.1% in Q1 to 4.4% last month.
- **Activation gaps.** Mobile activates at half the web rate or less. Teams that invite teammates early keep paying much longer.
- **Only SSO has revenue attached.** Brightwell signs $180k a year if SSO ships by quarter end.

Plan

Order	Item	Eng-weeks	Total	Why
1	A. Sync reliability fix	12	12	Biggest churn and support signal
1	E. SSO (SAML)	6	18	$180k contract, hard deadline. Runs alongside A.
2	C. Teammate invite prompts	3	21	Cheap test of the invite gap
3	B. Mobile onboarding redesign	8	29	Mobile activation gap. First to shrink if A or E overrun.
4	F. AI v1 scoping	1	30	Sets up an AI build next quarter
	Reserve	**6**	**36**	At +25%, the plan takes 37.5 weeks. If unused by week 8, it goes to scoping calendar sync.

Deferred (44 engineer-weeks)

Item	Eng-weeks	Why it waits
D. Calendar sync	10	Strongest deferred case (18% of cancellations, most paid votes). First in line next quarter.
F. AI assistant v1	16	44% of capacity; demand evidence is 41 waitlist responses.

Item	Eng-weeks	Why it waits
H. Gantt view	14	No churn or support signal.
G. Dark mode	4	Most votes, but 9% of voters pay.

Success metrics

Metric	Now	Target
Sync tickets per month	520	200 or fewer, 8 weeks after the fix ships
Brightwell contract	Not signed	Signed by quarter end
Mobile week-1 activation	20%	26%, 30 days after onboarding ships

Guardrail: monthly churn back to 3.6% or lower by quarter end.

Message to the CEO

> The AI assistant isn't in next quarter's build. It would take 44% of our capacity while sync is costing us customers now: sync tickets nearly quadrupled, and it's the top reason teams cancel. The 68% survey figure came from 41 people on the AI waitlist, so it doesn't show demand from paying teams.
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> This quarter I'll scope a narrow v1 and test it with paying teams, so we can start building next quarter. Can we talk this week? I need to know whether "this half" is a board commitment, and whether a smaller v1 would meet it.

What to check before committing

- **Brightwell:** Sales confirms signed scope, deadline and identity provider.
- **Estimates:** Engineering breaks down A and E, with dependencies and staffing.
- **Sync cause:** Support and Engineering compare tickets and incidents before and after the July launch.
- **Funnel, retention and survey counts don't add up:** 976 conversions vs 1,400 teams, a retention cohort as big as the whole customer base, and 312 survey answers vs about 185 cancellations. Ask Data for a team-level extract.
- **Weak signals:** 4.4% churn is one month. Feature votes are mostly from free users.

Assumptions

- Estimates are taken as given (±25%), with no dependencies between items.
- AI scoping (1 week) and the 26% activation target are my estimates.
- Revenue per team is $1,714 ($2.4M ÷ 1,400 teams).

Sources: tandem_data.xlsx, the assessment brief, and the Tandem planning dashboard.